

Atom OS

KEY INSIGHT_

“The hardest part wasn’t adding features. It was deciding what to withhold.”

PROBLEM_

Subtraction is a design decision.

Atom OS redesigns the smartphone experience by removing distractions and replacing them with four intentional widgets. The phone should feel deliberately limited, not broken, just focused.

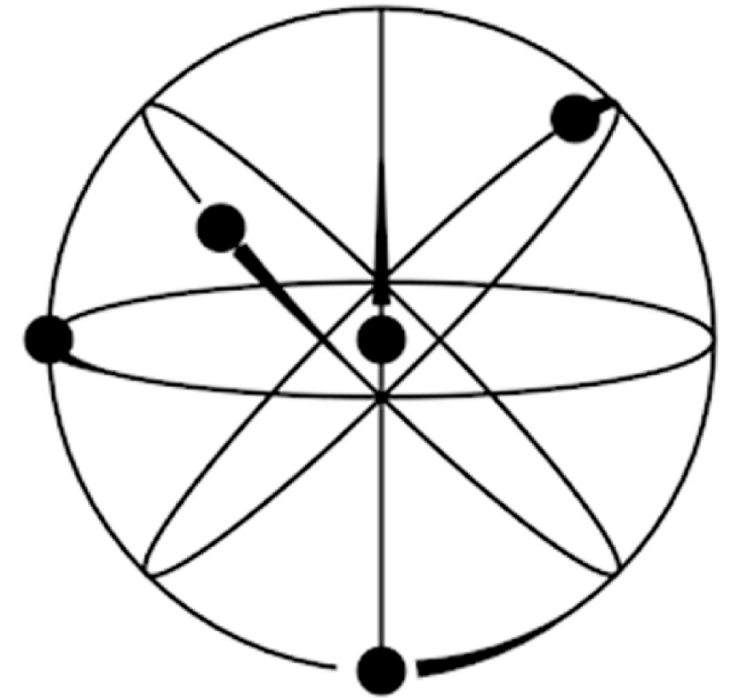
MY ROLE_

Sole designer across concept, UI design, and prototyping.

SOLUTION_

Four widgets. One focus. No noise.

A stripped-back phone OS with screen-time visualisation, app usage breakdowns, and a toggleable Focus mode that blocks selected apps for user-defined periods.



The need came from exam season. Existing solutions were too rigid or too blunt.

The concept started from a personal need to make the phone feel less compulsive without turning it into something unusable. The design had to balance intention with utility.

RESEARCH_

The problem was not screen time alone, it was the quality of attention.

I mapped two user types: students under academic pressure and professionals trying to reduce compulsive social media habits without losing essential phone functions.

CHALLENGE_

Deliberate limitation had to feel designed, not broken.

Early explorations focused on widget hierarchy and black-and-white UI treatment so the phone would feel quieter and less psychologically magnetic without becoming hostile to use.



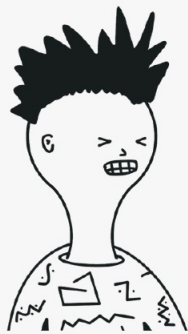
Sarah Kim

Demographics:
Age: 21
Location: New York City
Profession: University Student

Background:
Sarah is a university student studying sociology. She spends a significant amount of time on social media, which has begun affecting her mental well-being and academic performance. She also feels guilty about not being present during real-life conversations with friends and family.

- Frustrations:**
 - Feels pressure and anxiety from content seen on social media.
 - Apps designed to reduce screen time don't fully remove distractions.
- Goals:**
 - Reduce social media screen time to improve focus and mental health.
 - Use tools like meditation and focus widgets to adopt healthier habits.
 - Reconnect with her friends and family without the distraction of her phone..

Needs:
A minimalistic phone operating system that removes unnecessary distractions, promotes healthier habits, and helps her feel more present in real-life situations.



Jonathan Morales

Demographics:
Age: 28
Location: London
Profession: Young Professional (Tech Consultant)

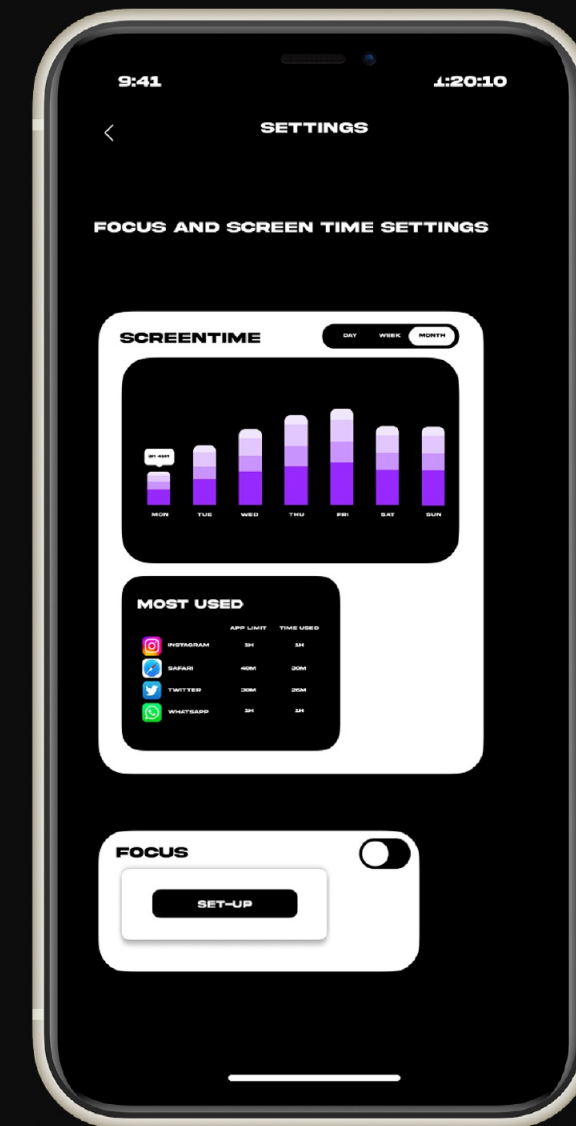
Background:
Jonathan works a demanding job and is constantly glued to his phone for work and social media. He notices that his habit of doomscrolling before bed and during breaks impacts his productivity and sleep. Social media often leaves him feeling pressured and left out, especially when comparing his lifestyle to others.

- Frustrations:**
 - Finds it hard to put his phone down without "something else to do."
 - Social media makes him feel anxious and unproductive.
- Goals:**
 - Disconnect from social media to alleviate feelings of social pressure and anxiety.
 - Use essential tools like books, focus timers, and meditation apps to build healthier routines.
 - Achieve a more balanced lifestyle while remaining productive.

Needs:
An intuitive OS that strips his phone down to the essentials, removes distractions, and encourages more mindful usage to improve his mental well-being.

Four widgets. One focus. No noise.

A four-widget home screen with screen-time visualisation, app usage breakdowns, and a toggleable Focus mode that blocks selected apps for user-defined periods.



OUTCOME_

Atom OS taught me that subtraction itself is a design decision.

APPROACH_

Minimal micro-interactions and clear widget hierarchy kept the system intentional, not sterile.

NEXT_

The next step is onboarding that explains the philosophy before the product asks users to adapt.